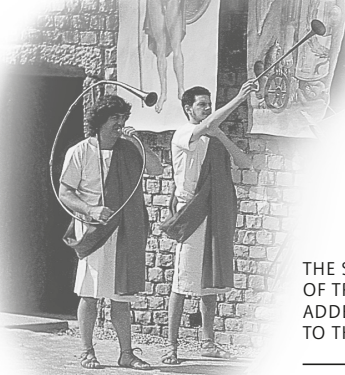




THE SHRILL SOUND OF TRUMPETS ADDED DRAMA TO THE CONTEST.

Who fought who

Several pairs of gladiators fought at the same time, with certain types often matched against each other. For example, a *murmillo* often fought a *thraex*. The *murmillo* was armed with a short sword called a *gladius* (from which we get the word "gladiator"). This type of gladiator carried a tall, rectangular wooden shield and was protected by head, arm, and leg armor. A *thraex* carried a smaller shield and fought with a short, curved sword. The *thraex*, too, was protected by armor, but the torsos of both types of gladiators were left bare, providing visible flesh for an opponent to strike at.

The *retiarus's* usual opponent was the *secutor*. The *secutor* had a specially designed helmet that was round and smooth so that it wouldn't get caught in the *retiarus's* net. It had two small eye holes to protect the *secutor's* eyes from the *retiarus's* trident.

Rules are rules

Movies often give the impression that gladiators fought in a frenzy, exchanging wild blows with each other. They didn't. The truth is that gladiator duels were skillful fights with strict rules to follow. Unfortunately, we don't know much about the rules. What we do know is that referees had the power to halt a fight. For instance, if a piece of armor fell off, the referees could stop the fight while the gladiator put it back on—and then the fight continued.

Delivering the knock-out blow

If the gladiators were not fighting hard enough, referees sent attendants called *lorarii* (named after their "*lora*" or leather straps) to thrash the fighters. It was all part of the entertainment, and the crowd loved it. As blood began to flow, the cheering increased. And when a gladiator fell to the ground, the crowd knew the fatal blow could soon be on its way.

Fallen gladiators had one chance for survival. As they lay on their backs, they raised their left hands to appeal for mercy. If they

